

Cycle of violence

The term **cycle of violence** refers to repeated and dangerous acts of [violence](#) as a cyclical pattern associated with high emotions and doctrines(belief) of [retribution](#)(punishment) or [revenge](#). The pattern, or cycle, repeats and can happen many times during a relationship. Each phase may last a different length of time, and over time the level of violence may increase. The phrase has been increasingly widespread since first popularised in the **1970s**.

It often refers to violent behavior learned as a child, and then repeated as an adult, therefore continuing on in a perceived cycle



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1. Within a relationship.

A cycle of abuse generally follows the following pattern:^[1]

- **Abuse** – The abuser initiates aggressive, [verbal](#) or [physical abuse](#), designed to [control](#) and oppress the victim.
- **Guilt** – The abuser feels guilty for inflicting abusive behavior, primarily out of a concern of being found guilty of abuse rather than feelings of sympathy for the victim.
- **Excuses – Rationalization** of the behavior, including [blame](#) and excuses.
- **"Normal" behavior** – The abuser regains personal control, creates a peaceful phase in an attempt to make the victim feel comfortable in the relationship.
- **Fantasy** and planning – thinking of what the victim has done wrong, how they will be punished, and developing a plan to realize the fantasy.
- **Set-up** – the plan is "put in motion."

A cyclical nature of **domestic violence is most prevalent in intimate terrorism** (IT), which involve a pattern of ongoing [control](#) using emotional, physical and other forms of domestic violence and is what generally leads victims, who are most often women. It is what was traditionally the definition of domestic violence and is generally illustrated with the "Power and Control Wheel" to illustrate the different and inter-related forms of abuse.

THE CYCLE OF VIOLENCE AND POWER AND CONTROL

The cycle of violence is a pattern of behaviors which keeps survivors locked in the abusive relationship.

There are three stages to the cycle of violence:

1. **First is the tension building phase.** In this phase, the batterer gets edgy and tension begins to build up. This is where the battered person may feel like they are walking on eggshells.
2. Second is **the actual explosion phase** where the physical abuse occurs. It can last from a few minutes to several hours.
3. Third is the **honeymoon phase**. The perpetrator may be sorry or act like nothing happened; but is still interested in making up and may even promise never to do it again. However, the tension almost always starts to build again, thus continuing the cycle.

Often the **psychological abuse** can **leave someone feeling fearful, helpless and powerless to act on their own behalf**. People affected by domestic violence are rich, poor, married, divorced or single, from **all ethnic backgrounds and economic levels**. They can be able-bodied or with a disability, heterosexual or homosexual, gay, lesbian, bisexual and/or transgender. As someone affected by domestic violence and battering they will find that they have common issues with many others who have also experienced this type of violence.

The **Power & Control diagram** is a particularly **helpful tool** in **understanding the overall pattern of abusive and violent behaviors**, which are used by a batterer to establish and maintain control over their partner. Very often, one or more violent incidents are accompanied by an array of these other types of abuse. They are less easily identified, yet firmly establish a pattern of intimidation and control in the relationship.



Power & Control Wheel

EMOTIONAL ABUSE

Putting her down or making her feel bad about herself, calling her names, making her think she's crazy, and mind games.

ECONOMIC ABUSE

Trying to keep her from getting or keeping a job, making her ask for money, giving her an allowance, or taking her money.

SEXUAL ABUSE

Making her do sexual things against her will.

USING CHILDREN

Making her feel guilty about the children, using the children to give messages, using visitation as a way to harass her.

THREATS

Making and/or carrying out threats to do something to hurt her emotionally, threaten to take the children, commit suicide, or report her to welfare.

USING MALE PRIVILEGE

Treating her like a servant, making all the "big" decisions, acting like the "master of the castle"

INTIMIDATION

Putting her in fear by using looks, actions, gestures, loud voice, smashing things, destroying her property.

ISOLATION

Controlling what she does, who she sees and talk to, where she goes.

2. Intergenerational.

Intergenerational cycles of violence occur when violence is passed from parent to child, or sibling to sibling. Children exposed to domestic violence are likely to develop behavioral problems, such as regressing, exhibiting out of control behavior, and imitating behaviors. Children may think that violence is an acceptable behavior of intimate relationships and become either the abused or the abuser.^[9] Recent research has questioned whether certain effects of domestic violence exposure on children are moderated and/or mediated by maternal psychological response such as maternal post-traumatic stress disorder, dissociation, and related biological markers.^{[10][11]}

An estimated 1/5 to 1/3 of teenagers subject to viewing domestic violence situations experience teen dating violence, regularly abusing or being abused by their partners verbally, mentally, emotionally, sexually and/or physically. Thirty to 50% of dating relationships can exhibit the same cycle of escalating violence in their marital relationships.^[12]

[Physical punishment](#) of children has also been linked to later [domestic violence](#).^[13] Family violence researcher [Murray A. Straus](#) believes that disciplinary [spanking](#) forms "the most prevalent and important form of violence in American families", whose effects contribute to several major societal problems, including later assaults on spouses.^[14]

3. In politics.

According to [John J. Mearsheimer](#) the cycle of violence between nations will continue indefinitely because the [Great powers](#) fear each other, thus compete for power and dominance, in the belief that this will ensure safety.^[15]

'Cycle of violence' is also used more generally to describe any long-term factional dispute within a nation in which [tit-for-tat](#) acts of aggression occur frequently, as for example in [Argentina](#) in the 1970s,^[17] in [Lebanon](#) and [Israel](#).^[18]

